

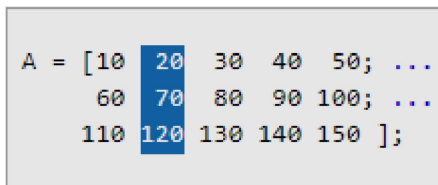
Edit and Format Code

To edit your code, in the Editor and Live Editor, you can use column selection, code autocompletion, and refactoring. To format your code and make your code easier to read, use indentation, text-width indication, code folding, and the Outline panel.

Column Selection

When adding or editing code in the Editor and Live Editor, you can select and edit a rectangular area of code (also known as *column selection* or *block edit*). If you want to copy or delete several columns of data (as opposed to rows) or if you want to edit multiple lines at one time, selecting and editing code is useful. To select a rectangular area, press the **Alt** key while making a selection with the mouse. On macOS systems, use the **Option** key instead.

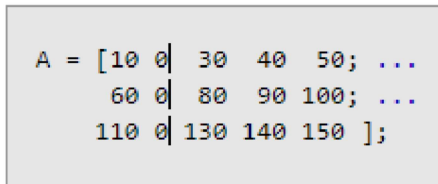
For example, select the second column of data in A.



```
A = [10 20 30 40 50; ...
     60 70 80 90 100; ...
     110 120 130 140 150];
```

The screenshot shows a MATLAB code editor with a matrix A. The second column of values (20, 70, 120) is highlighted with a blue background, indicating a column selection.

Type 0 to set all the selected values to 0.



```
A = [10 0 30 40 50; ...
     60 0 80 90 100; ...
     110 0 130 140 150];
```

The screenshot shows the same matrix A after the selected column has been replaced with zeros. The values 20, 70, and 120 have been replaced by 0.

Before R2021b: Column selection is available only in the Live Editor, not in the Editor.

Change Case

You can change the case of selected text or code from all uppercase to lowercase, or vice versa, in the Editor and Live Editor. Select the text, right-click, and select **Change Case**. Alternatively, you can press **Ctrl+Shift+A**. If the text contains uppercase and lowercase text, MATLAB® changes the case to all uppercase.

On macOS, use the **Command** key instead of the **Ctrl** key.

*Before R2021b: The **Change Case** option is available only in the Live Editor, not in the Editor.*

Duplicate and Copy Line

You can duplicate a code line in the Editor and Live Editor. To duplicate a code line, right-click the line and select **Duplicate Line(s)**. Alternatively, you can press **Ctrl+Shift+C**. On macOS, use the **Command** key instead of the **Ctrl** key.

To copy a code line without selecting the code, press the **Ctrl+L** keyboard shortcut. To cut the code line, press **Ctrl+X**. On macOS, use the **Command+C** and **Command+X** keyboard shortcuts instead. (since R2025a)

*Before R2021b: The **Duplicate Line** option is available only in the Live Editor, not in the Editor.*

Automatically Complete Code

MATLAB automatically completes parentheses and quotes when entering code in the Editor and Live Editor. For example, if you type an open parenthesis in the Editor or Live Editor, MATLAB adds the closing parenthesis. MATLAB also automatically splits comments, character vectors, strings, and parentheses when you press **Enter**. For example, if you

press **Enter** in a comment, MATLAB moves the text after the cursor to a new line and adds a percent (%) symbol to the beginning of the new line.

MATLAB can also automatically complete block endings in control flow statements and function and class definitions. To autocomplete block endings, on the **Home** tab, in the **Environment** section, click  **Settings**. Select **Editor/Debugger > Suggestions and Autocompletions** and in the **Autocoding options** section, select one or more of the **Autocomplete block endings** options.

To undo an automatic code completion, press **Ctrl+Z** or the  **Undo** button. To disable all automatic code completions, in the **Autocoding options** section of the **Editor/Debugger > Suggestions and Autocompletions** settings, clear the **Enable autocoding** setting. Alternatively, to disable only certain automatic code completions, clear one or more of the settings in the **Autocomplete pairs**, **Autocomplete on new line**, and **Autocomplete block endings** sections. For more information, see [Editor/Debugger Settings](#).

Before R2021b: MATLAB completes code only in the Live Editor, not in the Editor.

Refactor Code

You can break large scripts or functions into smaller pieces by converting selected areas of code into functions or local functions, known as code *refactoring*.

To refactor a selected area of code:

1. Select one or more lines of code.
2. On the **Editor** or **Live Editor** tab, in the **Code** section, click  **Refactor** and select from the available options.
3. Enter a name for the new function. MATLAB creates a function with the selected code and replaces the original code with a call to the newly created function.

Before R2021b: Refactoring options are available only in the Live Editor, not in the Editor.

Indent Code

Indenting code makes functions and statements, such as while loops, easier to read. By default, MATLAB automatically indents code in the Editor and Live Editor as you type. This is called *smart indenting*. When you indent lines by using tabs or spaces, MATLAB also aligns subsequent lines with those lines.

To indent selected lines of code if smart indenting is disabled, go to the **Editor** or **Live Editor** tab and in the **Code** section, click the Smart Indent  button.

To manually change the indent of selected lines to be farther right or left, on the **Editor** or **Live Editor** tab, click the Increase Indent  or Decrease Indent  buttons. Manually changing the indent works whether smart indenting is enabled or disabled. Alternatively, you can use the **Tab** key or the **Shift+Tab** keys, respectively.

Disable Smart Indenting

If you prefer not to use smart indenting, you can disable it. Each language in MATLAB that supports smart indenting has its own setting to disable it.

1. On the **Home** tab, in the **Environment** section, click  **Settings**.
2. Select **MATLAB > Editor/Debugger > MATLAB Language** or **MATLAB > Editor/Debugger > Other Languages > Language name**, where *Language name* is the programming language that you want to disable smart indenting for.

*Before R2025a: Select **MATLAB > Editor/Debugger > Language** and in the **Language** drop-down list, select a programming language.*

3. In the **Indenting** section of the selected language, clear the **Apply smart indenting while typing** setting. This setting is not supported for all languages.

Change Indenting Behavior

You can change the behavior of indenting in the Editor and Live Editor.

To change how functions in MATLAB code files indent, on the **Home** tab, in the **Environment** section, click  **Settings**. Select **MATLAB > Editor/Debugger > MATLAB Language**. Then, in the **Indenting** section, select from the **Function indenting format** options. For more information and examples of each function indenting format, see [Editor/Debugger Settings](#).

To change the behavior of smart indenting, go to the **MATLAB > Editor/Debugger > Indenting** settings and clear or set one or more of the smart indenting settings. For more information, see [Editor/Debugger Settings](#).

*Before R2025a: To change how functions in MATLAB code files indent, select **MATLAB > Editor/Debugger > Language**. To change the behavior of smart indenting programmatically, use the `matlab.editor` settings. For example, this code enables formatting the entire document when automatically indenting. For more information, see [matlab.editor Settings](#).*

```
s = settings;  
s.matlab.editor.indent.SmartIndentEntireDocument.PersonalValue = 1;
```

Fold Code

Code folding expands and collapses blocks of MATLAB code in the Editor. You can use code folding to hide code that you are not currently working on. Code folding improves the readability of a file that contains numerous functions or other blocks of code. Code folding is not supported in the Live Editor.

For example, you can fold:

- Code sections
- for and parfor blocks
- Function code
- Class code
- Multiline comments

To expand or collapse a block of code, click the plus  or minus sign  that appears to the left of the construct in the Editor. Alternatively, you can use the **Ctrl+Shift+.** (**period**) and **Ctrl+.** (**period**) keyboard shortcuts or use the code folding buttons in the **View** tab.

To expand or collapse all of the code in a file, place your cursor anywhere within the file, go to the **View** tab, and select the **Expand All**  or **Collapse All**  buttons. Alternatively, you can use the **Ctrl+Shift+.** (**comma**) and **Ctrl+.** (**comma**) keyboard shortcuts.

Note

If you print a file with one or more collapsed constructs, those constructs are expanded in the printed version of the file.

You can change which programming constructs can be folded and whether a programming construct is collapsed the first time that you open a MATLAB file. On the **Home** tab, in the **Environment** section, click  **Settings**. Select **Editor/Debugger > Code Folding**, and then adjust the setting options.

Change the Right-Side Text Limit Indicator

By default, a light gray vertical line (rule) appears at column 75 in the Editor, indicating where a line exceeds 75 characters. You can set this text limit indicator to another value, which is useful, for example, if you want to view the code in another text editor that has a different line width limit. The right-side text limit indicator is not supported in the Live Editor.

To hide or change the appearance of the vertical line:

1. On the **Home** tab, in the **Environment** section, click  **Settings**.

2. In the Settings window, select **MATLAB > Editor/Debugger > Display**.
3. Adjust the settings in the **Right-hand text limit** section.

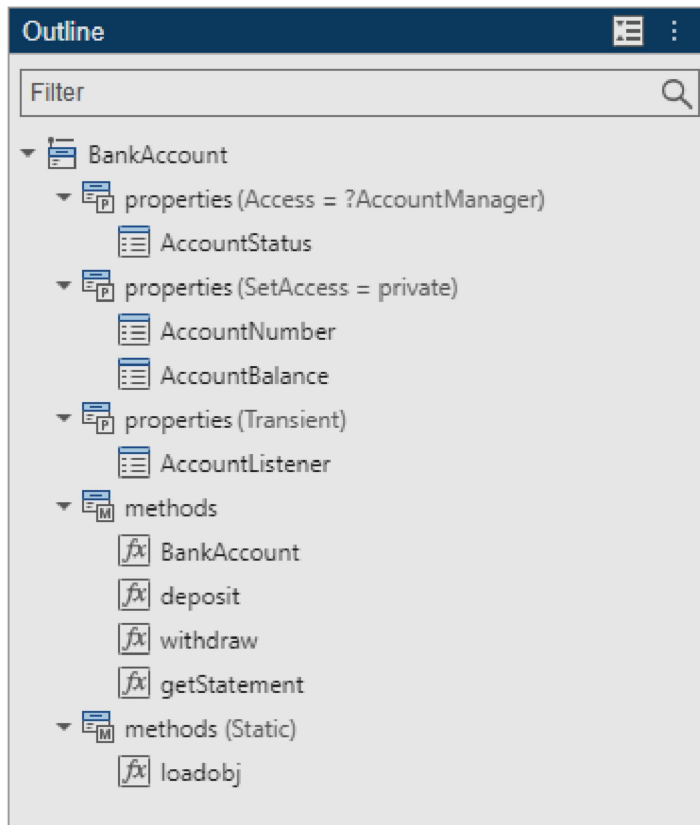
The right-side text limit indicator is a visual cue only and does not prevent text from exceeding the limit. To wrap comment text at a specified column number automatically, go to the **Home** tab and in the **Environment** section, click  **Settings**. Select **MATLAB > Editor/Debugger > MATLAB Language**, and adjust the **Comment formatting** settings.

*Before R2025a: Select **MATLAB > Editor/Debugger > Language** and in the **Language** field, select **MATLAB**.*

View Outline of Code

Since R2025a

In the Editor and Live Editor, you can view a high-level outline of MATLAB code files using the Outline panel. To view an outline of a file open in the Editor or Live Editor, go to the **View** tab, and in the **Tools** section, click **Outline**. To navigate to an area within your code file, double-click the related entry in the Outline panel.



See Also

Topics

[Create Scripts](#)

[Create Live Scripts in the Live Editor](#)

[Format Text in the Live Editor](#)

Teaching Resources

- [Programming: Structuring Code \(MathWorks Teaching Resources\)](#)